



3D notebook screens?

Acer, Dell, HP, Lenovo and Sony to look forward to notebooks with Stereo 3D Screens

GT300 fab issues

NVIDIA receives first test samples of next-generation chip the GT300 family. But fab yields could be as low as 20 percent

accurate and fast. The left-click and right-click buttons are well placed and long therefore you can use them with thumb and little finger while your index finger is on the trackpad. The S/PDIF and audio out share a single smart detect port. The ID 5801 is larger, with a 15.6-inch display and has a very sleek, contoured profile when viewed from the side owing to the speaker being incorporated inside a casing that starts from the top of the keypad and slopes upwards with a gentle curve till it runs into the display. On a negative design note the bezel is wide and looks ugly compared to the rest of this beauty. Finished in navy blue with chrome trimming she is a beauty. Brawny too! – in every respect. A tank like build and great quality of materials on the exterior coupled with a fast Core 2 Duo processor, 4 GB of RAM and an NVIDIA GeForce G105M GPU mean the ID5801 has enough grunt to tackle anything, well almost anything.

The keys are nicely laid out and the keypad feels very comfortable to use. Key travel and feedback is also excellent albeit soft and we really liked its design. The trackpad is very responsive and tracks quite accurately. The mouse buttons feel a bit clicky. Shortcut keys are red LED backlit and work well, they're also ultra legible.

The slot loading optical drive has a neat eject button on the edge of the notebook face. A shocking omission is the exclusion of a dedicated Wi-Fi switch, although a keypad shortcut does exist. Acer's Aspire 5738G is identical in terms of looks, to its siblings in the previous category. Obviously this similarity is only skin-deep and its innards include a potent NVIDIA GeForce G105M and 4 GB of main memory. Once again the keypad is identical in look and feel, excellent! Like the other Aspire notebooks the

trackpad lock button is an annoyance preventer of sorts, especially since the trackpad is not recessed; meaning it gets activated easily while typing causing typos.

HCLs Z39 made us do a double take when we saw the amount of RAM – 8 GB is virtually unheard of on desktops, let alone notebooks. It has a nice surface finish and is well built and sturdy. Looks wise its very plain looking.

Lack of shortcut keys and such prevent it from being too usable. The Function key on the outer portion of the keypad means any shortcuts involving use of the Ctrl key are going to be a royal pain. The keys have a slightly firm feedback; people used to squishy Sony keypad beware!

However keypad feedback is good as is the feel. The trackpad is glossy and due to this fingers tend to stick on the surface coating, meaning tracking is not accurate. The lack of a hard Bluetooth switch on this notebook is a glaring omission. The Lenovo Y550 has a nice onyx colour with a matte finish on the outer body but the inside is a glossy grey that is as unappealing as the outer part is attractive.

The trackpad is textured and this imparts good feedback, but tracking accuracy is not as good as the best, courtesy some much unwanted lag. The trackpad is also small and this may pose an issue for some people. The mouse buttons are nice and large and soft to press. The keypad feels like hard rubber with solid feedback. Key spacing is minimal and layout is good, most people will be up and running with this keypad – we had no

issues. Lenovo has used good speakers for the Y550 and for the first time the beginnings of bass are audible, although the speakers on the costlier Lenovo Y650 are much better.

The Lenovo Y550 also has the distinction of having the most powerful GPU from amongst all the notebooks here barring the gaming laptops – the NVIDIA GeForce GT130M is a powerful solution and we reckon this model can just as easily substitute for a gaming notebook. A fully featured Media Centre remote unit is also bundled and this works well in conjunction with Windows Vista – a sweet addition and the unit itself is pretty compact.

When it comes to value one cannot deny the appeal of the solid Acer Aspire 5738G, a good mix of features, build and performance for a down to earth price – Rs. 40,999. It topped the Best Value charts in this segment and we're duly awarding it. HCLs Z39 is a little too costly for the features on offer and its plain looks will put many people looking to spend this much off. If you're looking at spending around Rs. 50,000 the Lenovo Y550 warrants mention – great build quality and powerful components, just live with the mediocre colour combination used.

HIGH-END DESKTOP REPLACEMENTS ABOVE RS. 60,000:

Big bang, big bucks

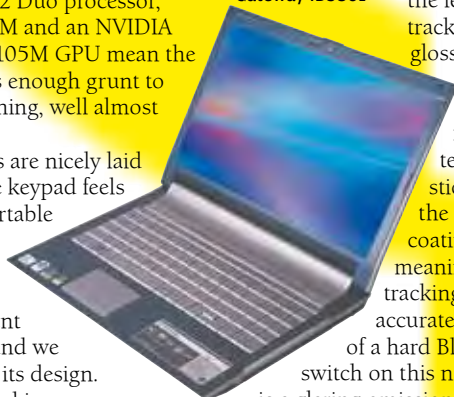
This is a category created for high-end, non-compact

notebooks that are not meant for hardcore gamers. Notebooks in this category are for power users who want power sans portability. That's not to say you cannot heat one of these around. It's just that a wonderful large screen cannot be incorporated into a small notebook. If you are shopping for a notebook priced at above Rs. 60,000 for home use you are somewhat of a rare breed and of course you expect a lot more as well – great components with the possibility of customisation, a great screen suitable for video and gaming, support for HDMI in order to hook your notebook up to an HDTV.

This duo are miles apart in terms of their personas and also the user base they will appeal to. Enter the Dell Studio XPS 1640 – classy build quality including glossy finished fibre and genuine leather. It's built like a tank and has blatantly muscular looks. There is none of the loose panels that custom assembled notebook assemblers (like Dell) are known for. Superb build quality and a superb RGB-LED display as an option along with high-performance components make the Studio XPS 1640 a standout in any crowd. Add to that a very well designed pseudo-segregated keypad and dedicated ATI graphics in the form of the Radeon 3670 and you have a recipe capable of feeding nearly every want except one – the hardcore gamer. The Lenovo Y650 is a very different beast – it's very slim and compact for its massive 16-inch screen and the notebook feels very

light thanks to the use of carbon fibre in the construction. The notebook is obviously meant for enthusiast multimedia users and the integrated Blu-Ray writer is testament to this. The graphics solution is also very respectable (NVIDIA GeForce GT 105M). A pity the screen doesn't support a higher

Gateway ID5801



Dell Studio XPS 1640

